Common Cold and Influenza (Flu)

Patient education sample document. For educational purposes only; not medical advice.

Cold versus flu

Both the common cold and influenza are respiratory illnesses caused by viruses, but influenza is usually more severe. The common cold is most often caused by rhinoviruses. Influenza is caused by influenza A and B viruses.

Symptoms of the common cold

- Gradual onset over one to two days.
- Runny or stuffy nose and sneezing.
- Sore throat and mild cough.
- Mild tiredness. Fever is uncommon in adults.

Symptoms of influenza

- Sudden onset of symptoms.
- Fever and chills.
- Severe body aches and headache.
- Extreme fatigue and a dry cough.
- Sore throat and sometimes a runny nose.

Treatment

Antibiotics do not work against viruses and should not be used for colds or flu. Treatment focuses on rest, drinking plenty of fluids, and over-the-counter medicines such as paracetamol (acetaminophen) or ibuprofen to reduce fever and aches. For influenza, antiviral medicines such as oseltamivir can shorten the illness if started within 48 hours of symptoms, and are especially important for people at high risk of complications. Children and teenagers should not be given aspirin because of the risk of Reye syndrome.

Prevention

- Get a flu vaccine every year.

- Wash hands often with soap and water for at least 20 seconds.
- Cover coughs and sneezes with a tissue or your elbow.
- Avoid close contact with sick people and stay home when you are ill.
- Avoid touching your eyes, nose and mouth.

When to seek medical care

Seek medical help if you have difficulty breathing or shortness of breath, chest pain, confusion, severe or persistent vomiting, or signs of dehydration. Also seek care if a fever lasts more than three days or if symptoms improve and then return with a worse fever and cough. People at higher risk include young children, adults over 65, pregnant women and people with chronic conditions such as asthma, diabetes or heart disease.